

RESEARCH PROPOSAL



Client: University of Nebraska-Lincoln

Researcher: Sydney Schmitz

BACKGROUND

This research proposal is for the University of Nebraska-Lincoln, which is a public land-grant university located in Lincoln, Nebraska. I've selected this client because I am a student worker and tour guide for the university's Office of Admissions. For this research proposal, I will explore how prospective students perceive the university while on a campus tour.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVE

To understand how campus tours influence prospective students' perceptions of the University of Nebraska-Lincoln and to find ways to improve recruitment.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. What are the best sources of information that prospective students use to learn about UNL?
2. What do both parents and students value the most on their campus tour?
3. What are UNL's campus visits lacking and where are its recruitment efforts least effective?

SECONDARY RESEARCH

Currently, [UNL's undergraduate enrollment](#) for fall of 2024 was 36,446, which is a 0.8% increase from the year prior. The total enrollment was 49,749, which is a 0.7% increase. What stands out the most is that the university saw a 1% increase in resident students and

a 0.5% decrease in enrollment of non-residential or out-of-state students in fall of 2024. While it is not surprising that majority of students enrolled are Nebraska residents, the university still has its reach across the country. [Google Trends](#) reports that just in the past seven days, the University of Nebraska-Lincoln was searched for in 38 out of 50 states under the search category of jobs and education, showing that students from other states are still a potential target market that is not being maintained. The [University of Nebraska-Lincoln](#) offers several different on-campus events such as regular weekday tours, larger Saturday event days and tailored experiences for a variety of students visiting from all over. Campus tours are a crucial part in high school students' decisions to attend a certain college. Tours offer the most immersive, realistic way for students to picture themselves attending and see if the school is a right fit. One of the most important things that both parents and students want to see on a campus visit is authenticity, according to a [U.S. News & World Report](#) article. University tours are practically a sales pitch and tour guides are the salespeople. Schools successful in recruitment strategies have student ambassadors who are trained to be a positive representation of the university while still being a relatable peer. Besides campus tours, there are other proven ways to improve recruitment and increase enrollment. In a study described in a [College Board](#) article, Moorpark Community College wanted to identify the most effective enrollment solution. To do so, the dean of institutional effectiveness and marketing conducted a strategic randomized controlled trial. In this trial, Moorpark sent out direct-mail postcards to students in the area, highlighting specific programs like Honors and dual enrollment. Overall, the college saw a 42% increase in enrollment between 2023 and 2024 after implementing the trial.

While this amount of secondary research explains the generalized, quantitative reasons behind college recruitment, it fails to answer the research objective which can be found through qualitative data and primary research. Secondary research gives us readily available and easy to understand information but has several limitations, primarily that it does not answer our specific objective. To answer these three research questions and the overarching research objective, it is necessary to conduct primary research. We can easily tailor primary research to accomplish this and fit the specific target audience of prospective UNL students and families.

PRIMARY RESEARCH METHODS

To meet the needs of the research objective, I will be employing exploratory research. This type of research is necessary because it will help us describe demographic characteristics and psychographic behavior and opinions held by our target market.

I will be collecting both qualitative and quantitative data.

Specifically, I will be using methods of ethnography and surveying. I will be using these methods of primary research because ethnography will involve in-person observations, helping us capture the authentic reactions and behaviors of families on a campus tour. This qualitative information will give insight into the decision-making process of attending college and answer what is valued by parents and students on a tour and what is currently lacking. Surveys will get us quantitative data that can be attributed to a larger population that we cannot reach in an affordable, efficient way. Through several responses, surveys will answer what the best sources of information are when it comes to learning about UNL.

OBSERVATION

For this research method, I will do a direct observation without manipulating the environment of a typical campus tour. To carry out this observational study, the researcher should conduct a shop-a-long observation with the perspective student/family and “shadow” the entire 90-minute Husker Weekday campus tour. With the participants aware that they are being observed, this will be an obtrusive observation. Some important observable phenomena the researcher should take note of are interactions between tour guide and student, the student’s body language and facial expressions for engagement and the number of questions asked.

While on the observational tour, the researcher should ask questions and conduct an in-depth interview about the decision-making process of potentially attending this university. The researcher should take notes accordingly and let the entire group be aware that audio is being recorded. These questions will gauge their immediate, in-the-moment thoughts and opinions. Although this will be an obtrusive observation, the researcher should be sure to walk towards the back of the group and do their best to not interfere with the tour guide’s ability to do their job. The researcher should attend 20 tours of varying sizes (some one-on-one and some in larger groups) with 20 different tour guides to obtain a sufficient amount of data. All observations should be conducted within the span of one month. The observation guide is as following:

Introduction (2 min)

Thank you for agreeing to be a part of this observation. My name is (researcher’s name). I am a researcher for the Office of Admissions at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln. I will be joining you while on your campus tour to observe how campus tours influence prospective students’ perceptions of UNL and how to improve visitor experience and recruitment tactics. Along the way, I will be asking you questions about your thoughts and opinions. I will be using audio recording and

note-taking throughout this time for future use. At the end of the tour, you will receive a \$5 coupon for the UNL Dairy Store as a thank you for your participation and cooperation.

Ice Breaker (3 min)

1. Before we begin the tour, can you please share your name, year in school, where you are visiting from and if this is your first time visiting campus?

[Ask each family member with the student their name and if this is their first visit to campus]

2. Before coming to campus today, what were your expectations of UNL?
3. What made you schedule a campus tour for today?

Questions During Tour (90 min)

[Direct following questions toward student and make note of observable phenomena]

1. What about campus is standing out to you so far?
2. Can you describe how you're feeling as you walk through campus?
 - a. What is contributing to that feeling?
3. How comfortable do you feel to ask your tour guide questions?
4. In what ways is your tour guide enhancing or diminishing your campus visit?

Post-tour Questions (10 min)

1. Is there anything that wasn't included on tour that you wish you could've seen?
2. Is there anything the tour guide could've done different to enhance your experience?
3. Did this campus tour change your opinions about UNL?
 - a. If yes, how so?
4. How did this tour compare to other campuses you've visited?

Conclusion (1 min)

Do you have any final thoughts or comments to add about your campus visit? Thank you for your input and cooperation. Here is your \$5 UNL Dairy Store coupon!

SURVEY

For this next research method, I will conduct a survey. The target population is high school or transfer students who are looking to pursue higher education. Families of these students will also be included in an alternate survey. For this study, the target population size is estimated to be 10,000, the average number of campus visitors in a semester. The sample will be 370. At the 95% confidence level, this study will have a margin of error of +/- 5%. A sample technique would be to use systematic probability sampling, asking every 4th group who registers for a visit to complete the survey after the tour. This would be a good method because it would ensure that both student and family/parent perspectives were reached and with an equal probability of being chosen, we can project the survey findings onto the larger population.

Thank you for your interest in this survey. We are collecting data on how perspective students and families perceive UNL when they come for a campus tour. This will be used to improve recruitment strategies. Please complete this survey within the week following your campus tour.

1. Screener: Are you a prospective undergraduate UNL student? (This will direct the survey between students and other members on the tour)
 - a. No
 - b. Yes

STUDENT QUESTIONS

2. What is your current status as a student? (This is the student survey)
 - a. Not yet in high school
 - b. High school freshmen
 - c. High school sophomore
 - d. High school junior
 - e. High school senior
 - f. Transfer student/in college
 - g. Untraditional student
3. How would you rate your campus tour overall? (semantic differential)
 - Poor
 -
 -
 -
 - Excellent
4. How did the tour influence your excitement to attend UNL? (semantic differential)

- Much less excited
 -
 -
 -
 - Much more excited
5. How effective was the tour in your understanding of the following areas regarding UNL? (matrix table)
- a. Academic programs
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
 - b. Student life
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
 - c. City of Lincoln
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
 - d. Student resources
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
6. What was the most valuable part of the tour? (open response)
7. What was the least valuable part of the tour? (open response)

NON-STUDENT QUESTIONS

8. What is your relationship to the prospective student?
- a. Parent/guardian
 - b. Grandparent

- c. Sibling
 - d. Aunt/uncle
 - e. Friend
 - f. Counselor
 - g. Other ____
9. How would you rate the campus tour overall? (semantic differential)
- Poor
 -
 -
 -
 - Excellent
10. How did the tour influence your excitement for your student to potentially attend UNL? (semantic differential)
- Much less excited
 -
 -
 -
 - Much more excited
11. How effective was the tour in your understanding of the following areas regarding UNL? (matrix table)
- a. Academic programs
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
 - b. Student life
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
 - c. City of Lincoln
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective

- v. Extremely effective
 - d. Student resources
 - i. Not effective at all
 - ii. Slightly effective
 - iii. Moderately effective
 - iv. Very effective
 - v. Extremely effective
12. What was the most valuable part of the tour? (open response)
13. What was the least valuable part of the tour? (open response)

DEMOGRAPHICS

14. What is your gender?
- a. Male
 - b. Female
 - c. Other
 - d. I do not wish to indicate
15. What is your age?
- a. Enter age here: _____
16. What is your ethnicity? (Please check all that apply)
- a. American Indian or Alaska Native
 - b. Asian
 - c. Black or African American
 - d. Hispanic or Latino
 - e. Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
 - f. White
 - g. Other: _____
17. What is your annual income?
- a. Under \$30,000
 - b. \$30,000 to \$50,000
 - c. \$50,001 to \$70,000
 - d. \$70,001 to \$90,000
 - e. Over \$90,000

PRETEST RESULTS

I decided to pretest the survey as my primary research method. In order to obtain my sample for this pretest, I asked a few friends to reflect on their campus tour of UNL and

respond according to that time period. I also made sure to get a respondent who toured UNL but does not attend to avoid complete bias in responses. To reach the non-student demographic, I asked my mom to do the same reflection after my visit. Additionally, I had a friend's younger sibling take the survey who just toured campus about one month ago for a more recent, relevant response. Systematic probability would be the ideal sampling method but I did my best to get a range of responses.

Overall, this pretest met my expectations with how it would go. A few adjustments I could make is to change the two open response questions to be less general and broad to avoid respondents entering N/A or survey fatigue. I should also include the preface to the survey so respondents know what they are taking, what it will be used for and the time frame they have to complete it.

With the [data](#) this pretest collected, it reveals that majority of visitors had a positive experience while on their campus tour. The mean for how would you rate your campus tour overall was a 4.2 which signifies close to an excellent experience. Another takeaway from these responses is that prospective students and families value hearing from current students while on tour. This is something that should definitely be continued and even increased to make the tour more valuable than just visiting the website for information. As for the entries in the least valuable part of the tour, most of them are things that could easily be fixed, like seeing more or less academic buildings/classrooms. Overall, campus tours need to focus on the personal experience while also balancing in-depth information that prospective students would get using other resources to improve UNL's recruitment tactics and perceptions.